

CRITICAL VIEWING The Great Mosque in Djenné (jen-AY), Mali, is an architectural wonder. A mosque is a Muslim place of worship. What distinctive features does the photo show?

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3.2 Mali and Songhai

In the 1300s, new legends spread to Europe about an impossibly wealthy king from West Africa who traveled with hundreds of camels and thousands of servants. This man, Mansa Musa, gave away so much gold that it led to a decline in the precious metal's value in parts of Africa.

MAIN IDEA Wealth from the kingdoms of Mali and Songhai spread along trans-Saharan trade routes to northern Africa and Europe.

MALI TAKES OVER GHANA

After Ghana's decline in the 1200s, the kingdom of **Mali** took control of the gold and salt trades in West Africa. Mali's first king was **Sundiata Keita** (sun-JAHT-ah KAY-tah). Sundiata led military forces to defeat the weakened kingdom of Ghana, uniting the conquered lands into a peaceful, prosperous empire stretching along the Niger River and up into the Sahara.

Though Sundiata ruled well, it was **Mansa Musa** who first introduced Mali to the world. Musa became king in the 1300s. As a Muslim, he decided to make a **pilgrimage**, or religious journey, to the holy city of Mecca in 1324. He took thousands of servants and dozens of camels. The caravan gave gold and other luxurious goods to people along the way. Europeans and Asians, upon hearing accounts of the generous king, became more motivated to trade with the wealthy empire.

Mansa Musa returned from Mecca a year later with new knowledge and ideas. He turned the city of Timbuktu into a center for culture and learning. He also encouraged his people to learn Arabic so they could study the holy book of Islam, the Qur'an.

SONGHAI

The **Songhai** people lived to the east of the Mali Empire. Their capital city, Gao, became such a wealthy, thriving city that the Mali Empire conquered it in 1325 and ruled over it for the next 50 years. When the Songhai finally retook their capital city, they began to build their own empire. In the process, Songhai assumed control of trans-Saharan trade. The Songhai ruler Askia Mohammed then continued to expand the kingdom and strengthen ties with other Muslims. He also reformed government, banking, and education. Later rulers fought each other for control, making the Songhai vulnerable to the ambitions of their envious neighbors. Songhai lost Timbuktu and its capital, Gao, when Morocco captured the two cities in 1591. The invasion by Morocco marked the end of the Songhai Empire.

As Ghana, Mali, and Songhai rose and fell, other West African cultures developed. The Hausa (HOW-suh) and Yoruba (YOR-uh-buh) practiced agriculture and crafts. While the Hausa and Yoruba were allied with each other, they never combined forces to engage in war for other territories. The kingdom of Benin (buh-NEEN) rose to power in the late 1400s, conquered many of its neighbors, and successfully engaged in trade with Europeans.

The Europeans, meanwhile, had set their sights on other lands by the late 1400s. Soon they would be exploring territory in the Americas.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the rise of Mali and Songhai affect trans-Saharan trade?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did Mansa Musa's pilgrimage lead to changes in Timbuktu?
3. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the empires of Mali and Songhai similar?

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